





RACHIT GOSWAMI

1. Firoza Begum from Naini, Prayagraj, shows off her Moonj craft

2. Handicraft workers at the India International Trade Fair in 2019

3. An installation at the Mumbai airport

4. Craft-based furniture at the India Design Fair in Delhi in 2022



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began flooding rural markets, the government, with its subsidies and grants for the development and promotion of crafts, kept them alive. National and state awards, and later the Padma Shri and Shilp Guru status, were accorded to craftspeople.

While almost all crafts were supported and promoted only by the government, some business establishments in Kashmir, Rajasthan and Gujarat, and a few other players, had developed connections earlier with importers from abroad. Carpets, gems and jewellery were the only significant exports in the '70s. In the '80s, some state emporia came into their own. My personal experience of linking rural producers with the urban market through design and innovative marketing strategies, with the launch of Gurjari, a Gujarat state government enterprise, was a runaway success and lent inspiration to other government outlets for crafts. One of the major contributions of Gurjari in the '80s was the discovery and promotion of handblock printed textiles, tie-dye fabrics, a vast range of exquisite embroideries and weaves that even lent themselves to India's first post-Independence boutiques run by fledgling entrepreneurs. Sonia Gandhi, actors Shabana Azmi, Nina Gupta, the late Smita Patil, and Teji Bachchan, among others, were regular shoppers at Gurjari, which became the trendiest place in the capital.

By then, the National Institute of Design, set up by Pupul Jayakar and which initially aspired to focus on industrial design, began to pay serious attention to craft. The National Institutes of Fashion Technology gave a fresh impetus to crafts, under which young fashion designers soon realised that Indian craft skills were the key to creating what was innovative and uniquely Indian, while adapting to a highly contemporary form for global markets. Then, private design institutions that focused on crafts followed.